

Compass

A clear and careful way to ask questions across five years of grant knowledge

Case Study and Skills Demonstration

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September 2026

Scope note

This document answers the requested scoping exercise. I also created a small optional demo using invented records to test parts of the idea. No GitLab Foundation systems, credentials, or private information were used.

Supporting work: [Live Compass demo](#) | [Source code on GitHub](#)

My approach

My approach is simple: understand the decision before choosing the technology. I want a program officer to ask a question, receive an answer in plain language, and open the records behind every important statement. If the records disagree or the evidence is weak, the answer should say that clearly.

The four systems play different roles. GivingData may hold the official grant record. Google Drive may contain reports and the fuller story. Airtable may show relationship and cohort information. Zoom Chat may explain why a decision changed. The solution should connect those pieces without pretending they are the same kind of information.

I would start with a small, read-only pilot focused on a few questions the Programs team asks repeatedly. I would begin with GivingData and one approved Google Drive folder. I would add Airtable after the team confirms how its records should be used. I would leave Zoom Chat for later because conversations require clearer decisions about consent, retention, and which channels belong in scope.

Why I made a demo

The assignment asked me to scope the problem, not build a product. The scope is my answer. After completing it, I built a contained demo with invented information to challenge my own assumptions. I wanted to see whether an answer could show its sources, call out a conflict, and refuse to overstate what the evidence proves. The demo is optional supporting evidence, not a recommendation that the Foundation adopt this exact interface or code.

[Open the live demo](#) | [Review the GitHub repository](#)

What the first version should accomplish

- Answer a small set of important questions that the team chooses.
- Show a direct link to the source behind every important statement.
- Respect the access already set in each source system.
- Show when information is missing, out of date, or in conflict.
- Keep people responsible for interpretation and every grant decision.

1 Context

Before I design anything, I need to understand who will use it, what decision follows the answer, which information the team trusts, and what each person is allowed to see.

People and decisions

- Which questions come up repeatedly during grant reviews, renewals, strategy work, and partner conversations?
- What does a useful answer allow someone to do next?
- Who owns the final decision when records disagree?
- Where does important context live only in one person's memory?
- What language could damage trust with a grantee if it appeared without context?

Information and meaning

- How do we know that records in four systems refer to the same organization or grant?
- Which system owns the official amount, status, payment, requirement, contact, or result?
- How does the team distinguish an expected outcome from an outcome that has actually been reported?
- Which definitions or calculation methods changed during the five-year period?
- Which files are drafts, final versions, duplicates, or no longer current?

Access and responsibility

- Who may see each folder, base, grant record, channel, or conversation?
- What information should never enter the search system?
- Should direct messages ever be included? My starting answer would be no.
- How much Zoom history actually exists, and what retention rules apply?
- When someone deletes a source record or removes access, how quickly must the copied information disappear?

This discovery work produces a short list of priority questions, a clear owner for each kind of information, an access map, and a starting measurement for how long the work takes today.

2 The system

The system should make the path from source to answer visible. Each step has an owner, a safety check, and a clear response when something goes wrong.

1 Agree on the role of each source

For every approved collection, document what it contains, who owns it, how often it changes, who may see it, and which fields are sensitive. This prevents the system from guessing which record is official.

2 Copy only approved information

Bring in records from approved folders, tables, and grant collections. Keep the original link, date, author, version, and access setting. If the source changes or disappears, update or remove the copy.

3 Match records carefully

Create a simple cross-reference that connects the same organization or grant across systems. Use stable identifiers where possible. Send uncertain matches to a person instead of merging them automatically.

4 Check access before searching

Confirm the person and their approved account. Remove anything they cannot already open before the search begins. Recheck access when they open a source link.

5 Find and explain the evidence

Search exact names and amounts as well as similar ideas. Use structured records for totals and dates. Use reports and notes for explanation. Return a short answer with source links and clearly label any calculation, conflict, or missing information.

6 Review and improve

Let users mark an answer useful, incomplete, or wrong and explain why. Save enough history to investigate problems without storing unnecessary private text in logs. Use real staff questions to test quality before expanding the pilot.

What a person receives

- A direct answer in everyday language.
- Links to the records supporting the answer.
- The date range and systems that were checked.
- Any disagreement, missing coverage, or uncertainty.
- The person who owns the next confirmation or decision.

3 Risks and edge cases

I would design the failure response as carefully as the successful answer. The system should never hide a conflict or fill a gap with confident language.

Risk	How I would reduce it	What the user should see
Private information appears	Check access before searching and again before opening a source.	Stop the answer and create a security alert.
A forecast looks like a result	Label the type of number, date, population, and calculation method.	Show expected and reported results separately.
Two records disagree	Agree on which system owns each fact.	Show both records, their dates, and who should resolve the difference.
Two organizations get combined	Use stable identifiers and review uncertain matches.	Keep the records separate until a person confirms the match.
Zoom history is incomplete	Check retention before promising five years of coverage.	Show exactly which dates and channels are missing.
There is too little evidence	Require enough supporting information and working source links.	Say that the system does not know and explain what is missing.
A document contains unsafe instructions	Treat all retrieved text as information, never as permission to take an action.	Ignore the instruction, limit connected tools, and quarantine suspicious content.

Confidence should describe the quality and coverage of the evidence, not how certain the AI sounds.

4 First version tradeoffs

The first version should prove that a small group of people can find and verify useful information safely. I would rather answer a few important questions well than search everything and create false confidence.

Include at first	Leave out at first
Five to ten questions tied to one real Programs decision cycle	Direct messages or broad Zoom Chat access
A carefully selected group of grants	Changing source records automatically
GivingData and one approved Drive folder	Proposal scores, renewal recommendations, or risk labels
Read-only answers with source links	Access for the entire organization or external users
Programs users and named review partners	Connecting every historical file at once
Feedback and a review history	A product sold to other foundations

Why these limits matter

Each excluded item adds a new kind of risk or requires a decision the team has not made yet. Keeping the pilot read-only and narrow gives the Foundation useful evidence without forcing a larger commitment.

The optional demo boundary

The demo uses invented records. It does not connect to Foundation systems, represent production security, make decisions, or change records. Its only purpose is to show how a cited answer could expose a conflict instead of hiding it.

Sequential implementation plan

I would move quickly, but I would not skip a decision that protects people, information, or the quality of the answer. Work can move ahead as soon as the entry condition for the next step is met.

1 Listen

Observe the current workflow. Choose the questions worth solving and name the person who owns each decision. Exit when the team agrees on the priority and what a good answer looks like.

2 Agree

Map which system owns each fact, who may see what, and what must never enter search. Exit when data owners and security reviewers approve the small pilot scope.

3 Test safely

Use invented records to test source links, conflicting information, missing evidence, and refusals. Exit only when the safety checks pass.

4 Pilot

Connect one approved source pair in read-only mode for a small group of users. Compare the answers with reviewer-approved examples and record what users correct.

5 Decide

Measure accuracy, time saved, trust, and unanswered questions. Let the team decide whether to continue, revise the design, or stop.

How I would measure success

- People answer the chosen questions faster than they do today.
- Reviewers can open and verify the support behind important statements.
- The system identifies missing or conflicting information before a decision.
- No person receives information outside their approved access.
- People return because the tool helps their work, not because they were asked to test a demo.

Closing

The value of Compass is not a polished interface. The value is a shared and trustworthy way to find what the Foundation already knows. The team remains responsible for interpretation, relationships, and every grant decision. I would bring the structure, technical judgment, and momentum to test that approach with them.

Limitations

This case study uses public information and invented examples. I do not know the Foundation's private record counts, system configuration, access rules, retention settings, data agreements, or real staff questions. Those are discovery questions, not details I should guess.